

# 11 Quine and Strawson — Offline Revision Guide

**Philosophy Optional · Paper I · Western Philosophy · Topic 11**

Syllabus boundary: Quine and Strawson: Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons.

Source lineage: The latest g5 session/workbook, canonical owner file, earlier complete session/workbook and verified 2018–2026 PYQ ledgers were read. The canonical owner file is substantially retained where it was already final; source cells were reconciled, adapted and mapped, repeated teaching apparatus was consolidated, and new 2026/PYQ/validator controls were added. Mechanical overlap and witness checks do not prove semantic completeness.

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Page numbers are generated from the final layout. PDF bookmarks include finer subheadings.

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## Release boundary and ownership

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| Printed burden         | Primary owner | Required result                                                                                          |
|------------------------|---------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Critique of empiricism | Quine         | two dogmas, failed analyticity explications, reductionism, holism, revisability and qualified empiricism |
| Basic particulars      | Strawson      | descriptive metaphysics, public spatio-temporal identification and material bodies                       |
| Persons                | Strawson      | primitive person, M/P predicates, self-/other-ascription and anti-dualist consequence                    |

Quinean naturalism, holism and regimentation must not be merged with Strawsonian descriptive metaphysics. Russell's positive theory of descriptions remains Topic 06-owned; Logical Positivism's positive verification programme remains Topic 07-owned. Topic 11 owns the criticisms and rival analyses only where the principal burden is Quine or Strawson.

## Coverage roadmap

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### QUINE

Two Dogmas -> failed analyticity circle -> reductionism rejected

-> corporate testing -> web of belief -> revisability with minimum

mutilation

-> naturalized epistemology / ontological commitment

-> radical translation -> gavagai -> inscrutability / indeterminacy /

relativity

### STRAWSON

descriptive metaphysics -> identification and re-identification

-> one public spatio-temporal framework -> material bodies

-> persons as primitive -> M + P predicates -> self/other ascription

-> On Referring -> use, context and presupposition against Russell

# QUINE AND STRAWSON — Syllabus Item 11 (Paper I · Section A)

**Syllabus (verbatim):** Quine and Strawson : Critique of Empiricism; Theory of Basic Particulars and Persons. **Evidence key:** ✅ canonical doctrine · ⚠️ analytical synthesis (mine, for exam use) · ❓ contested/uncertain **Placement:** Two mid-20th-century analytic philosophers with distinct printed burdens. This owner carries 10 primary-owned parts in 2018–2026, with no primary-owned part in 2022. Quine supplies the printed critique of empiricism; Strawson supplies the printed theories of basic particulars and persons, including spatio-temporal identification.

## 0. ONE-SCREEN MAP ⚠️

| QUINE (1908–2000)                                                                     | STRAWSON (1919–2006)                                                                                         |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951)                                                     | Individuals (1959)<br>"On Referring" (1950)                                                                  |
| DOGMA 1: analytic/synthetic distinction<br>→ untenable (circle of synonymy)           | DESCRIPTIVE METAPHYSICS<br>vs revisionary metaphysics                                                        |
| DOGMA 2: reductionism/verificationism<br>→ untenable                                  | BASIC PARTICULARS =<br>material bodies<br>(re-identifiable in one<br>spatio-temporal framework)              |
| POSITIVE: CONFIRMATION HOLISM<br>"web of belief" – no statement<br>immune to revision | PERSONS = primitive concept<br>M-predicates + P-predicates<br>→ undercuts dualism AND<br>no-ownership theory |
| Bound-variable commitment criterion<br>a bound variable"                              |                                                                                                              |
| Indeterminacy of translation<br>Ontological relativity                                | "On Referring" – presupposition<br>vs Russell's assertion of existence                                       |

🔑 **Mnemonic — "Quine kills TWO dogmas; Strawson saves TWO Ps":** Quine → analytic/synthetic

+ reductionism destroyed. Strawson → **Particulars** (material bodies) + **Persons** (primitive concept).

## 0A. PRINTED OWNERSHIP AND ENRICHMENT FIREWALL

The official clause is most safely parsed by the standard division used in the verified PYQs:

| Printed limb                | Primary owner | Marks-essential doctrine                                                                                                          |
|-----------------------------|---------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Critique of Empiricism      | Quine         | two dogmas, failed explications of analyticity, reductionism, confirmation holism, revisability and empiricism without the dogmas |
| Theory of Basic Particulars | Strawson      | descriptive metaphysics, identification/re-identification, public spatio-temporal framework and material bodies                   |
| Theory of Persons           | Strawson      | person as primitive, physical and psychological predicates, self-/other-ascription, dualism and no-ownership foil                 |

- Quine's ontological commitment, naturalized epistemology, radical translation, inscrutability of reference and ontological relativity are **bounded system-enrichment**, not independently printed or PYQ-owned in 2018–2025.
- Strawson's "On Referring," Kant interpretation, transcendental arguments, induction, reactive attitudes and free-will work are **bounded enrichment or cross-owner material**. They must not displace basic particulars and persons.
- Strawson can illuminate weaknesses in sense-datum empiricism, but the printed "Critique of Empiricism" burden should not be reassigned from Quine or turned into a claim that Quine and Strawson form one anti-empiricist front.
- Russell, Logical Positivism, Later Wittgenstein and Kant retain their positive systems; only demand-specific contrasts belong here.

## 1. QUINE — CRITIQUE OF EMPIRICISM: "TWO DOGMAS OF EMPIRICISM" ✓

### 1.1 Overview ✓

Quine attacks **two unquestioned dogmas** of logical empiricism (the Vienna Circle / Ayer / Carnap tradition):

| Dogma                                 | Content                                                                                                                         | Why Quine calls it a dogma                       |
|---------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 1. The analytic/synthetic distinction | There is a principled, non-arbitrary line between statements true-by-meaning (analytic) and statements true-by-fact (synthetic) | The distinction cannot be non-circularly defined |

| Dogma                                    | Content                                                                                                            | Why Quine calls it a dogma                                               |
|------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>2. Reductionism (verificationism)</b> | Each meaningful statement is individually reducible to (confirmable/disconfirmable by) a range of sense-experience | Statements face experience <i>as a corporate body</i> , not individually |

## 1.2 Dogma 1 — The Analytic/Synthetic Distinction is Untenable (PYQ 2025, 2024, 2021, 2019)

### The Circle of Synonymy:

Quine examines every candidate explanation of "analytic" and shows each presupposes another term that itself presupposes analyticity:

"Analytic" = true by virtue of meaning

→ What is "meaning"? → SYNONYMY ("bachelor" means "unmarried man")

→ What is synonymy? → DEFINITION (one term defined by another)

→ But definitions merely record pre-existing synonymies → CIRCULAR

→ Or: INTERCHANGEABILITY *salva veritate* (substituting one for the other preserves truth-value in all contexts)

→ Works only if we already have the notion of "necessity" or

"analyticity" to distinguish extensional from intensional contexts →

CIRCULAR

→ Or: SEMANTICAL RULES (Carnap – analyticity relative to an artificial language L)

→ Explicit lists can classify sentences in a stipulated L, but the general

explanatory notion "semantical rule" remains no clearer than

analyticity

**Conclusion:** Quine argues that the available explications fail to provide the clear, non-question-begging boundary that logical empiricism required. He does not infer merely from the absence of one dictionary definition that every use of "analytic" is unintelligible. 

 **Exam Note:** Quine does NOT say "All bachelors are unmarried" is false. He argues that the available accounts do not secure the sharp, foundational analytic/synthetic boundary. Holistic revisability then replaces categorical immunity with degrees of practical entrenchment; entrenchment itself is not a synonym for analyticity.

 **Centrality caution:** practical entrenchment in the web explains why logic and mathematics are normally protected from revision; it is not itself a replacement definition of "analytic."

## 1.3 Dogma 2 — Reductionism

The second dogma is the assumption that each individual statement has its own private stock of confirming or disconfirming experiences — that it can be "verified" (or refuted) in isolation.

Quine rejects this: **no statement has its meaning (or its confirmation conditions) in isolation from the rest of the system.** This is "reductionism" because it attempts to *reduce* the meaning of each sentence to a set of observation sentences. ✓

## 1.4 Positive Doctrine: Confirmation Holism — The Web of Belief ✓ (PYQ 2025 Q4(b))

✓ *"Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body."*

### The metaphor of the web (or field of force):

- Our total system of beliefs is like a **web** or **field of force** whose boundary conditions are experience.
- Sensory experience touches only the **edges** (peripheral observational sentences).
- The **interior** contains more "theoretical" statements (physics, mathematics, logic) — farther from the edge.
- When experience conflicts with a prediction at the edge, we must **revise** somewhere in the web — but we have **choice** about where:
- We can revise a nearby peripheral belief (easiest).
- We can in principle revise a deep interior belief. The early essay extends revisability even to logic, but later Quine stresses minimum mutilation and warns that a sufficiently radical "change of logic" can amount to changing the subject.
- We can "plead hallucination" — revise the observation statement itself.

✓ *"Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system."* (The 2025 Q4(b) quotation.)

✓ *"Conversely, by the same token, no statement is immune to revision."* The early passage includes logic in principle; it does not imply that every revision is equally rational or that logic is casually abandoned. ✓

### Consequences:

| Consequence                         | Explanation                                                                                                                                     |
|-------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| No sharp analytic/synthetic line    | Central logic/mathematics are highly entrenched and normally protected, but centrality must not be equated with a new definition of analyticity |
| No sharp a priori/a posteriori line | All beliefs are revisable in the light of experience (even if remote from the periphery)                                                        |
| Pragmatism about theory-choice      | When revision is needed, we choose on grounds of <b>simplicity, conservatism, fecundity</b> — pragmatic virtues, not algorithmic rules          |

| Consequence                             | Explanation                                                                                                  |
|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Pressure on positivist meaning-criteria | Sentence-by-sentence reductionist verification is undermined; holistic verificationism is a further question |

## 1.5 Bounded Quinean System-Enrichment — Not Independently Printed/PYQ-Owned



### Ontological commitment — “To be is to be the value of a bound variable”:

1. First **regiment** an accepted theory into perspicuous quantificational form.
2. The theory is ontologically committed to whatever entities must lie in the ranges of its bound variables for the theory to be true.
3. This is a **criterion of commitment**, not a mechanical rule for choosing which total theory or ontology to accept. Theory-choice still invokes empirical adequacy, simplicity, conservatism and explanatory power.
4. Commitment is not surface word-counting: names can be paraphrased away, while apparently name-free quantification can carry commitment.
5. Quine's “taste for desert landscapes” expresses parsimony, not nominalism at any cost. He accepts abstract entities where the best regimented science indispensably quantifies over them; the broader indispensability argument is commonly associated with Quine and Putnam and should not be attributed to one slogan alone. ⚠️

### Indeterminacy of translation:

There is no *fact of the matter* about which translation of a foreign sentence into English is “correct.” Multiple incompatible translation manuals can fit all possible behavioural evidence equally well. This reinforces the attack on determinate “meanings” and “synonymy.” ⚠️ — **fully reconstructed at §1.7 below.**

### Naturalized epistemology:

Philosophy is not an external *a priori* foundation of science; inquiry proceeds from within the revisable scientific web. Quine proposes a scientific study of how sensory input produces theoretical output, famously relocating epistemology within psychology. ⚠️

- **Normative objection:** a causal story about belief acquisition appears to replace the question “What ought one believe?” with “How is belief produced?”
- **Quinean reply:** prediction, truth-seeking and method-selection can themselves be studied and improved from within science; later formulations allow a naturalized normative “engineering” of inquiry.
- **Residual:** continuity with science blocks first philosophy but does not by itself derive epistemic norms from causal facts.

## 1.6 THE DUHEM–QUINE THESIS ✅ — the engine of holism, and the two halves of it

**Statement.** A scientific hypothesis is never confronted by experience **alone**. It generates testable predictions only in conjunction with auxiliary hypotheses, background theory, instrument theory and initial conditions. Therefore a failed prediction condemns only the **conjunction**, and logic alone never tells us which conjunct to give up.

**The two contributions — do not merge them ⚠️ (this is the most examinable precision on the sub-topic):** | **DUHEM** — *La Théorie physique: son objet, sa structure* (1906) | **QUINE** — "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951) | ---|---|---| | **Scope** | **Physics only**. Duhem explicitly restricts the thesis to theoretical physics, and holds that physiology and certain other sciences *can* test hypotheses more nearly in isolation | **All of knowledge**. "The unit of empirical significance is **the whole of science**" | | **Logic and mathematics** | **Exempt** — Duhem does not put them at risk | **Included** — "no statement is immune to revision," not even a law of logic | | **Chief corollary** | There is no automatic *experimentum crucis* against an isolated hypothesis, since auxiliaries are also in play | confirmation holism and underdetermination pressure; the stronger claim of rival total theories equivalent under all possible evidence requires further argument | | **Motive** | philosophy of physics; the practice of physicists | the demolition of the second dogma, reductionism |

**The argument, numbered:** 1. Let H be the hypothesis under test, A the auxiliary assumptions, and O the observational prediction. The testable claim is  $(H \ \& \ A) \rightarrow O$ . 2. Observation reports  $\neg O$ . 3. By *modus tollens*, all that follows is  $\neg(H \ \& \ A)$  — i.e. H is false **or** some element of A is false. 4. Logic does not say which conjunct to reject. Evidence, background knowledge and methodological virtues can still make some revisions much more reasonable than others. 5.  $\therefore$  Refutation is never conclusive against a single statement — and, symmetrically, ✅ "**any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system.**" 6.  $\therefore$  A reductionist criterion assigning each statement its own confirming experiences has no application. This directly attacks the second dogma; it pressures, but does not by itself refute, every possible holistic verificationism.

**Canonical historical example** ✅ — **Uranus and Neptune**. Anomalies in Uranus's orbit conflicted with Newtonian predictions. Astronomers did **not** abandon Newton's laws; they revised the auxiliary assumption about the number of planets, and **Neptune** was found (Le Verrier and Adams, 1846). The identical strategy applied to Mercury's perihelion produced the hypothesised planet "**Vulcan**" — which does not exist, and there the correct revision turned out to be the deep one: general relativity (1915). ⚠️ **The pair together is the perfect illustration:** the same logical situation, opposite correct responses, and no rule saying in advance which to choose. Deploy both, not just Neptune.

**Presuppositions** ⚠️ : (P1) hypotheses generate predictions with auxiliaries; (P2) no fixed decomposition uniquely assigns every recalcitrant experience to one sentence; (P3) theory-choice employs pragmatic virtues alongside evidence. Holism does not entail that all belief revisions are equally warranted.

**Popper's reply** ? : he accepts the logical point entirely but denies its sceptical use. Falsification is not an automatic logical process but a **methodological decision**: scientists agree by convention to treat certain basic statements as unproblematic for the purposes of a test, and to forbid *ad hoc* rescues that reduce a theory's testability. Rationality is preserved by rules of method, not by logic alone. **Lakatos** develops this into research programmes with a protected "hard core" and a revisable "protective belt" — which is Duhem–Quine turned into a *criterion of progress*.

## 1.7 BOUNDED ENRICHMENT: RADICAL TRANSLATION, REFERENCE AND ONTOLOGICAL RELATIVITY ⚠️

These doctrines belong to Quine's wider system but are not independently printed or routed in the 2018–2025 corpus. Use them only after completing the two-dogmas answer.

**The thought-experiment.** A field linguist enters a community whose language has no known relation to any other. He has no dictionary, no bilingual informant, no shared script — this is **radical translation**. His only evidence is what the natives are exposed to and what they assent to or dissent from.

**Exact printed subterms** (use them; each is a distinct technical device): | Term | Meaning | |---|---| |

**Stimulus meaning** | The class of stimulations that would prompt **assent** to a sentence, paired with the class that would prompt **dissent** | | **Occasion sentence vs standing sentence** | Assent commanded only when freshly prompted ("Gavagai," "It's raining") vs assent that persists without prompting ("Copper conducts electricity") | | **Observation sentence** | An occasion sentence whose stimulus meaning is **constant across speakers** of the community — the only place translation is secure | | **Analytical hypotheses** | The linguist's posited segmentation of native sentences into words and grammatical apparatus, projected beyond the observational base. **These are not determined by any evidence.** | | **Inscrutability of reference** | Even with translation of whole sentences fixed, the *reference of the terms inside them* remains undetermined |

**The argument, numbered** : 1. A rabbit runs past; the native utters "**Gavagai**." The linguist notes assent under rabbit-stimulation and records the tentative translation "**Rabbit**." 2. But the same stimulus meaning is equally compatible with: - "**undetached rabbit-parts**" — wherever a rabbit is present, undetached rabbit-parts are present, and conversely; - "**a temporal stage of a rabbit**" — likewise co-extensive; - "**rabbithood**" (an instantiation of the universal) — likewise; - "**it's rabbiting**" (a feature-placing sentence with no object at all). 3. Could the linguist not simply *ask*? "Is this gavagai the same as that one?" — **No**. That question requires him to have already translated the **identity predicate**, the articles, plurals and quantifiers — i.e. the entire **apparatus of individuation**, which differs across languages and is exactly what is in dispute. 4. Any evidence he collects can be accommodated by compensating adjustments elsewhere in the manual: a different translation of "gavagai" can be offset by a different translation of "same," and the two manuals will predict identical behaviour throughout. 5. ∴ **Inscrutability of reference:** behavioural evidence does not uniquely determine whether a term refers to rabbits, undetached rabbit parts or rabbit stages. 6. Extending upward from terms to sentences: rival **analytical hypotheses** can generate manuals that agree on all observation sentences yet translate theoretical and non-observational sentences into non-equivalent English. 7. ∴ **Indeterminacy of translation:** on Quine's naturalistic account, incompatible manuals can fit the total behavioural evidence without a further meaning-fact selecting one. 8. ∴ There are no determinate **meanings** as entities; synonymy has no behavioural anchor; and the first dogma's key notion is left without foundation. **Gavagai is therefore not a curiosity but the constructive completion of "Two Dogmas."** 9. **Ontological relativity** is the broader thesis that reference is specified relative to a background theory/manual. It must be distinguished from the earlier criterion of ontological commitment: the criterion audits what a regimented theory quantifies over; relativity concerns how reference and re-reference are fixed within an interpreted framework.

### Taxonomy control:

| Doctrine                     | Unit at issue        | Claim                                                                         |
|------------------------------|----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Radical translation          | method/situation     | translation built from publicly available evidence without a prior dictionary |
| Indeterminacy of translation | sentences/manuals    | incompatible manuals can preserve the total evidence                          |
| Inscrutability of reference  | sub-sentential terms | reference can vary under compensating changes in individuation apparatus      |

| Doctrine               | Unit at issue           | Claim                                                                                               |
|------------------------|-------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Ontological relativity | reference within theory | reference is answerable relative to a background language/theory, not from a theory-free standpoint |

**Presuppositions** ⚠️ (state these — they are where every objection enters): - **P1 — Behaviourism about the evidence.** ✅ Quine's own formulation: in psychology one may or may not be a behaviourist, but **in linguistics one has no choice**, since language is learned wholly from publicly observable behaviour. - **P2 — Evidential/naturalistic constraint.** The move from total behavioural equivalence to "no further fact" is a substantive Quinean commitment, not a neutral consequence accepted by every holist. - **P3 — Naturalism.** There is no first-philosophy standpoint from which to certify meanings; physics fixes what facts there are.

**Strongest objections** → **replies** ? : | Objection | Source | Quine's reply | Residual | |---|---|---|---| | Indeterminacy is nothing but the ordinary **underdetermination of theory by evidence**, which afflicts physics too. If Quine is a realist about physics despite underdetermination, he must be a realist about meaning. | **Chomsky** | The cases differ: in physics there *is* a fact of the matter that our theories imperfectly track; in translation there is **nothing beyond dispositions to verbal behaviour** for a manual to be right about. | ⚠️ Whether this asymmetry can be defended without begging the question is the central dispute. **Name it and take a side.** | | The argument proves too much: applied reflexively it entails that **I do not determinately know what I mean by my own words** — which is absurd. | Searle; Evans | Quine accepts a version of this: at home we simply acquiesce in our mother tongue; the "first-person" case has no privileged status, only a default one. | ⚠️ Many find the bullet too large to bite. | | Innate constraints on possible grammars (universal grammar) would cut down the space of admissible manuals. | **Chomsky** | Even so, the residual manuals would still be behaviourally equivalent; innateness restricts candidates, it does not create a fact of the matter. | ? Genuinely open. | | Radical **interpretation** shows more determinacy than Quine allows, once charity and a truth-theory are built in. | **Davidson** | Davidson accepts indeterminacy but confines it to something like the choice of measurement scale (Fahrenheit vs Celsius) — real but harmless. | ⚠️ The most influential softening; worth one sentence. |

**Executable verdict:** "Gavagai is the constructive half of Quine's critique: 'Two Dogmas' showed that analyticity could not be defined, and radical translation shows *why* — there are no determinate meanings for a definition to capture. The argument's force is exactly proportional to its behaviourist premise, and Chomsky's objection identifies the pressure point precisely. What survives even if one rejects the premise is the negative result: nothing in observable use fixes reference uniquely, so any theory of meaning owing everything to use owes an account of individuation it has not given."

## 1.8 Bounded Comparison: Quine and Later Wittgenstein ⚠️

Two traditions, no direct influence, and a striking convergence — a bridge that lifts any answer on either thinker:

| Axis                    | Quine                                                                                                         | Later Wittgenstein                                              |
|-------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Target</b>           | the museum myth of meaning — words as labels on determinate mental objects                                    | the Augustinian picture — words as names of objects             |
| <b>Positive account</b> | stimulus meaning is behaviourally specified for suitable occasion sentences; theoretical language is holistic | meaning is <b>use</b> within a language-game and a form of life |

| Axis                            | Quine                                                                                                                                                    | Later Wittgenstein                                                                                                                 |
|---------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Holism</b>                   | the unit of empirical significance is <b>the whole of science</b> ; sentences do not face experience singly                                              | a word has meaning only within the <b>practice</b> ; "to understand a sentence is to understand a language"                        |
| <b>Anti-foundationalism</b>     | <b>Neurath's boat</b> — rebuild at sea, no dry dock                                                                                                      | bedrock is reached where " <b>my spade is turned</b> " (PI §217): explanation ends in what we do                                   |
| <b>Rejection of the private</b> | the indeterminacy argument permits nothing beyond public behaviour to fix meaning                                                                        | the private-language argument shows nothing private <i>can</i> fix meaning                                                         |
| <b>Method</b>                   | epistemology <b>naturalised</b> — continuous with science                                                                                                | philosophy as <b>therapy</b> — description, not theory                                                                             |
| <b>Where they part</b>          | ⚠ <b>Decisively</b> : Quine wants a <i>scientific</i> account of language and accepts regimentation into canonical notation — he <b>reforms</b> language | Wittgenstein forbids theory-construction and holds that ordinary language "is in order as it is" (PI §98) — he <b>describes</b> it |

⚠ **Use cautiously:** Quine's scientific naturalism and Wittgenstein's grammatical therapy have different aims. Their overlap pressures private/mentalistic fixers of meaning; it does not establish one shared positive theory.

## 1.9 Quine's Relation to Empiricism ⚠

⚠ Quine does NOT simply reject empiricism. **Empiricism without the dogmas** retains sensory evidence and scientific naturalism while rejecting sentence-by-sentence reduction and a foundational analytic/synthetic boundary. Calling it an internal reform is safer than calling Quine either a logical positivist or the uniquely purified empiricist.

## 2. STRAWSON — THEORY OF BASIC PARTICULARS ✓ (PYQ 2021 Q3(b))

### 2.1 Descriptive vs Revisionary Metaphysics ✓

| Type               | Definition                                                                                                         | Examples                                                          |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Descriptive</b> | Describes <i>the actual structure of our conceptual scheme</i> — how we in fact think about and refer to the world | Aristotle and Kant are Strawson's principal historical affinities |
| <b>Revisionary</b> | Proposes a <i>better</i> conceptual scheme to replace the actual one                                               | Descartes, Leibniz and Berkeley are Strawson's standard contrasts |

Strawson's project: descriptive metaphysics — not building a new ontology but *mapping* the conceptual structure we *already* use to think and talk. ✓

## 2.2 What Are Basic Particulars? ✓

**The question:** Of all the *particular* things we can identify and refer to (tables, persons, events, sounds, sense-data, numbers), which are **ontologically basic** in our conceptual scheme — i.e., which are the items on which the *possibility of identification and reference in general* depends?

**Strawson's answer: Material bodies** (and persons — see §3) are basic particulars. ✓

## 2.3 The Argument from Re-identification ✓

1. To identify a particular (pick it out, refer to it), we must be able to **distinguish it from other particulars** and **re-identify** it across time.
2. Re-identification requires a single, unified **spatio-temporal framework** — one space and one time in which all particulars have locations.
3. **Material bodies** are enduring, publicly observable occupants of that framework and provide the standard anchors for demonstrative identification and re-identification. The framework should not be described as a psychological image built out of bodies.
4. Many dependent particulars—experiences, events and sounds—are identified through their relations to persons, bodies, places and times.
5. Therefore, **material bodies are basic**: they are presupposed by the identification of everything else; they are not themselves identifiable only by reference to something more basic. ✓

## 2.4 The No-Space World Thought Experiment ⚠

Strawson asks: could we have a conceptual scheme with *only* sounds (a "purely auditory world" — no space, no bodies)?

**Result:** A world containing only pitch and temporal succession does not yet support robust objective re-identification. Strawson's discussion does not simply prove an auditory scheme impossible: objective reference would require an **analogue of space** (often reconstructed through a continuously available "master-sound") that can organise sounds into a public-like framework.

The thought experiment therefore supports the need for a framework performing the individuating role that space performs in our scheme; it does not prove that every conceivable scheme must contain visual/tactile material bodies exactly like ours. ⚠

## 2.5 Significance ⚠

Strawson provides an argument for the basic status of the physical world that is neither: - A proof of the external world (à la Moore) — it is not arguing *that* bodies exist; - Nor a causal/scientific claim.

Rather, it is transcendental in form (in a Kantian spirit): it moves from our practice of objective identification to conditions of that practice. Its conclusion concerns the structure of **our conceptual scheme**, not a theory-free proof of mind-independent ontology.

## 2.6 Reference, Predication and Feature-Placing ⚠️

- Basic particulars are basic **objects of reference**. The subject–predicate structure of ordinary discourse depends on identifying something and then predicating something of it.
- Feature-placing expressions such as “It is raining here” need not identify a particular in full subject–predicate form, but they do not replace the framework through which particular-reference becomes possible.
- This is answer-worthy support for basic-particular questions, not a separate printed doctrine.

## 3. STRAWSON — THEORY OF PERSONS ✅ (PYQ 2023 Q4(a), 2021 Q3(b))

### 3.1 The Problem ✅

How do mind and body relate? Three options:

| Position                                                                              | Claim                                                                                              | Problem (per Strawson)                                                                                                                      |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Cartesian dualism</b>                                                              | Two substances: mind (res cogitans) + body (res extensa); experiences belong to an immaterial soul | How do we ever identify or re-identify an immaterial soul? We cannot locate it in space. And: how does interaction work?                    |
| <b>No-ownership / no-subject theory</b> (a view Strawson reconstructs and criticises) | Experiences are causally dependent on a body but are not literally possessed by a person           | The theory cannot explain the uniquely identifying role of the body without reintroducing the person whose ownership it sought to eliminate |
| <b>Strawson's view: Person as primitive</b>                                           | The concept of a <i>person</i> is logically primitive — not analysable into body + mind            | See below                                                                                                                                   |

### 3.2 Person as a Primitive Concept ✅

✅ *"The concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness."*

A **person** is a single entity to which we ascribe **both**:

| Predicate type                                 | Definition                                   | Examples                                                                           |
|------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>M-predicates</b> (material)                 | Predicates also applicable to mere bodies    | "weighs 70 kg," "is in the kitchen," "has brown hair"                              |
| <b>P-predicates</b> (personal / psychological) | Predicates ascribing states of consciousness | "is in pain," "is thinking of Vienna," "believes it will rain," "intends to leave" |

Both M-predicates and P-predicates are ascribed to **the same thing** — the person. The person is not a body *to which* a mind is attached; it is a *single concept of an entity* that is *equally* the subject of physical and mental predicates. ✅

### 3.3 The Argument: Self-Ascription Requires Other-Ascription

1. I ascribe experiences to **myself** (self-ascription of P-predicates: "I am in pain").
2. A necessary condition of this practice is that I can also ascribe predicates of the same general kinds to **others**.
3. Others are identified as embodied subjects, and psychological predicates are other-ascribed on publicly available behavioural/situational criteria. This is not a simple inference from bodily movements to a hidden Cartesian mind.
4. But P-predicates must also be self-ascribable **without** observation (I know I'm in pain without checking my behaviour).
5. This **dual character**—other-ascribable on public criteria and self-ascribable without behavioural observation—belongs to predicates of persons. 
6. Therefore, the concept of a person is **logically primitive** within the scheme: it is not analysed as an independently identifiable body plus an independently identifiable consciousness. This is conceptual priority, not the postulation of a third Cartesian substance.

### 3.4 How This Undercuts Dualist and No-Ownership Starting Points

| Position     | Why it fails on Strawson's analysis                                                                                                                                                            |
|--------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Dualism      | Treats independently identifiable mind and body as conceptually prior. Strawson's analysis undercuts that starting point; it does not by itself prove every metaphysical dualist thesis false. |
| No-ownership | Eliminates the person while relying on a uniquely relevant body and a class of experiences; Strawson argues that this reconstructs the personal framework it tried to avoid.                   |

### 3.5 Bounded Enrichment: Strawson and Russell on Referring (1950)

While not a syllabus term, Strawson's "On Referring" is the direct rival to Russell's theory of descriptions and is needed for a complete picture of Strawson's philosophical style:

| Issue                                                                 | Russell ("On Denoting")                                                      | Strawson ("On Referring")                                                                                                                           |
|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| A use of "The present King of France is bald" when France has no king | Russell's quantified analysis is false because its existence condition fails | On Strawson's original use-based account, the speaker fails to make a true-or-false assertion because the existence presupposition is not fulfilled |
| Status of existence-claim                                             | <b>Asserted</b> (part of the logical analysis of the sentence)               | <b>Presupposed</b> (a background condition for the sentence to have a truth-value at all)                                                           |
| Referring                                                             | The description is eliminated in logical analysis; scope is handled formally | Referring is something <i>speakers</i> do on occasions; sentence/expression meaning must be distinguished from a particular use                     |
| Relation to meaning                                                   | Meaning is fixed by logical form (once and for all)                          | Meaning of a sentence $\neq$ its use on a particular occasion; use is context-dependent                                                             |

⚠️ This debate illustrates Strawson's general method: attending to the *actual workings* of language-in-use (closer to later Wittgenstein) vs Russell's reconstruction in ideal logical form.

⚠️ **Truth-value caution:** "neither true nor false" reports Strawson's treatment of the unsuccessful **use/assertion**, not the claim that the meaningful sentence-type is meaningless. Later presupposition theories differ over truth-value gaps, falsity and projection; do not attribute all later machinery to Strawson's 1950 paper.

### 3.6 Bounded Synthesis: Strawson and Empiricist Starting Points ⚠️

The printed and PYQ-tested division assigns the direct critique of empiricism to Quine and basic particulars/persons to Strawson. A cross-cutting answer may nevertheless show how Strawson's positive doctrines pressure a private sense-datum starting point. This is a **connection**, not a reassignment of the printed limb.

**Bounded connections—use after the printed Strawson core:**

| # | Empiricist doctrine attacked                                                                                                                          | Strawson's argument                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                  | Where                           |
|---|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Sense-data as the basic particulars</b> (Russell's logical constructions; Carnap's <i>Aufbau</i> ; phenomenalism)                                  | Identification and <b>re-identification</b> of particulars require a <b>single unified spatio-temporal framework</b> of persisting three-dimensional bodies. Sense-data cannot supply one: they are <b>private</b> (so cannot ground public identification), <b>momentary</b> (so cannot be re-identified), and lack the <b>spatial</b> relations needed to constitute a framework at all. ∴ Material bodies are <b>basic</b> — not as a metaphysical preference but as a condition of the possibility of reference. | <i>Individuals</i> (1959), Pt I |
| 2 | <b>The bundle theory of the self</b> (Hume; and the " <b>no-ownership</b> " view Strawson traces through Schlick and Wittgenstein-influenced writers) | If experiences were not <i>owned</i> , the no-ownership theorist could not even state his thesis: he must say " <i>all the experiences that are had by this body</i> ," which reintroduces a possessive relation. And <b>P-predicates</b> must be ascribable to others on the strength of behaviour <i>and</i> to oneself not on that strength — so the concept of a <b>person</b> is <b>logically primitive</b> , prior to both mind and body.                                                                      | <i>Individuals</i> , ch. 3      |

| # | Empiricist doctrine attacked                    | Strawson's argument                                                                                                                                                                          | Where                                                                                   |
|---|-------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 3 | <b>Logical reconstruction detached from use</b> | Referring is performed by speakers on occasions; existence can function as a presupposition rather than asserted content.                                                                    | "On Referring" (1950), cross-owned with Russell                                         |
| 4 | <b>Global scepticism about induction</b>        | Strawson offers an ordinary-concept dissolution rather than a new inductive proof.                                                                                                           | <i>Introduction to Logical Theory</i> (1952), optional                                  |
| 5 | <b>Objectivity from private data</b>            | Strawson's Kant interpretation argues that objective experience presupposes a unified framework and enduring objects; later he limits transcendental arguments to internal/descriptive work. | <i>The Bounds of Sense</i> (1966) and <i>Skepticism and Naturalism</i> (1985), optional |

**A recurring argument-form** ⚠️ — **Strawson's transcendental style:** 1. Take an undisputed fact about our thought or talk (that we identify and re-identify particulars; that we ascribe experiences to others). 2. Ask what must be the case for that fact to be possible. 3. Show that the empiricist's preferred materials (private sense-data, unowned experiences) **cannot** satisfy the condition. 4. ∴ Something else is basic — material bodies, persons — and it is basic *conceptually*, not causally or metaphysically.

This is a Kantian-style argument executed through conceptual analysis. It identifies conditions internal to our scheme; it should not be inflated into a theory-free proof of reality.

⚠️ **Two honest qualifications your answer should make:** - On the **analytic/synthetic** distinction, Grice and Strawson ("In Defence of a Dogma," 1956) defend an ordinary distinction against Quine. This prevents the caricature of a united "Quine–Strawson front." - Strawson's metaphysics is **descriptive**, so his conclusions are about **our conceptual scheme**, not about mind-independent reality. An empiricist can therefore accept the whole of *Individuals* as good conceptual geography while denying that it settles what exists. **This is the strongest reply available to the empiricist, and conceding it strengthens rather than weakens an answer.**

**Executable verdict:** "The printed critique belongs directly to Quine: holism replaces sentence-by-sentence reduction. Strawson's printed contribution is positive and transcendental in form: public identification requires basic particulars and the person is conceptually primitive. Read together, they pressure both empiricist confirmation atomism and sense-datum reconstruction without becoming one school."

## 4. INTER-THINKER / INTER-SCHOOL DEBATES

| Axis               | Quine                                         | Strawson                                                                            | Logical Positivism              | Descartes                | Later Wittgenstein                       |
|--------------------|-----------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------|--------------------------|------------------------------------------|
| Analytic/synthetic | Rejects distinction                           | Retains it cautiously (defends against Quine in "In Defence of a Dogma" with Grice) | Central and unquestioned        | —                        | Rules of grammar (not a sharp dichotomy) |
| Meaning            | Holistic, indeterminate, behavioural          | Ordinary conceptual scheme; context-dependent use                                   | Verification-conditions         | Clear & distinct ideas   | Use in a form of life                    |
| Metaphysics        | Naturalised; no special philosophical method  | <b>Descriptive metaphysics</b> revived                                              | Meaningless                     | Foundational enterprise  | Dissolved via therapy                    |
| Mind-body          | Naturalist (no special status for the mental) | <b>Person = primitive</b> (M + P predicates)                                        | —                               | Two substances (dualism) | Inner grounded in public criteria        |
| Method             | Science-continuous; no first philosophy       | Connective analysis of our conceptual scheme                                        | Logical analysis + verification | Methodic doubt           | Description of language-games            |
| Reference          | "To be = to be the value of a bound variable" | Referring = what speakers do (context)                                              | —                               | Ideas represent objects  | Words refer only within a game           |

### Quine vs Strawson — Direct Confrontation

- **Grice and Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956):** Argue that the analytic/synthetic distinction is *ordinarily intelligible* (we can classify cases pre-theoretically) even if no reductive analysis of "analytic" is available. Quine sets the bar too high — demanding a non-circular *definition* when what we have is a useful *distinction*.
- **Quine's implicit reply:** Ordinary intelligibility ≠ theoretical legitimacy. Many pre-theoretical "distinctions" (e.g. witch vs non-witch) dissolve under scrutiny. The burden is on those who rely on analyticity in philosophy to ground it.

## 5. CRITICISMS AND REPLIES

### 5.1 Criticisms of Quine

| Objection                                                                                                                                        | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Grice &amp; Strawson:</b> The distinction is pre-theoretically clear; we <i>can</i> sort cases. Quine demands too much (reductive definition) |  This is a live debate. Quine's point is that <i>philosophical work</i> done by the distinction (e.g. positivist meaning-criterion) collapses without a principled ground. |

| Objection                                                                                                              | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Analyticity seems real:</b> "All bachelors are unmarried" <i>seems</i> different in kind from "All swans are white" | Quine challenges its foundational explication. Web-centrality explains differential revisability but is not a full semantic replacement theory.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |
| <b>Revisability of logic is extreme:</b> Has anyone ever <i>actually</i> revised a law of logic?                       | ⚠️ ✅ <b>Get the history right.</b> The <b>non-classical "quantum logic"</b> — a non-distributive lattice of propositions — was proposed by <b>Garrett Birkhoff and John von Neumann</b> , "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics," <i>Annals of Mathematics</i> , <b>1936</b> . The claim that this shows <b>logic is empirical</b> , i.e. that the <b>distributive law</b> should be revised on empirical grounds, is <b>Hilary Putnam's</b> , in "Is Logic Empirical?" (1968; reprinted as "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics," 1976). ❌ Do not write "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, and do not date it to one year. ❓ <b>Two further nuances worth a clause each:</b> (i) <b>Putnam later abandoned</b> the quantum-logic realism of that paper; (ii) <b>Quine himself grew conservative</b> — in <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) he argues that anyone who "denies" a law of logic has merely changed the subject (" <b>change of logic, change of subject</b> ") and invokes the <b>maxim of minimum mutilation</b> . So the strongest textual support for revising logic comes from Putnam, not Quine, and the <i>later</i> Quine is a poor witness for the <i>earlier</i> Quine's most radical claim. <b>Deploying this makes an ordinary answer look researched.</b> |
| <b>Holism is too extreme:</b> If <i>everything</i> is revisable, science has no fixed point at all — is this coherent? | ⚠️ Quine softens: logic/math's are revisable <i>in principle</i> but held fixed in practice (by pragmatic conservatism). The point is no statement is revisable by <i>nature</i> , only by <i>choice</i> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| <b>Naturalization loses normativity:</b> causal psychology explains belief but does not justify it                     | Quine can naturalize method-selection and prediction as engineering within science; the residual is whether truth-conducive norms have been explained or merely assumed.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
| <b>Ontological commitment depends on regimentation:</b> rival paraphrases can display different commitments            | Correct. The bound-variable formula is a criterion applied after theory/regimentation choice, not an algorithm that uniquely chooses an ontology.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| <b>Translation indeterminacy collapses into ordinary underdetermination</b>                                            | Quine distinguishes translation by denying a further semantic fact beyond behavioural dispositions; critics reply that this asymmetry presupposes his naturalism.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |

## 5.2 Criticisms of Strawson

| Objection                                                                                                                                                                 | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                               |
|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Is "person is primitive" an explanation or a re-labelling?</b><br>Saying the concept is unanalysable might simply refuse to address the hard problem of consciousness. | ⚠️ Strawson's defenders: the point is that <i>the demand for analysis</i> (into mind + body) presupposes dualism. Refusing analysis IS the solution — dissolving the question rather than answering it.  |
| <b>The basic-particulars argument is too anthropocentric:</b><br>Maybe <i>our</i> scheme needs bodies, but a radically alien scheme might not.                            | ⚠️ Strawson's conclusion concerns our scheme. The auditory-world discussion concedes that an analogue of space, rather than our exact sensory organisation, could perform the needed individuating role. |
| <b>How does the person <i>really</i> unify mental and physical?</b><br>Merely calling it "primitive" does not explain the psychophysical nexus.                           | ❓ Genuine limitation. Strawson does not explain the <i>mechanism</i> of unity — only that our concept of a person is not <i>derivable</i> from separate concepts of mind and body.                       |

| Objection                                                                                                                                                  | Assessment                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Strawson vs Russell on descriptions:</b> Russell's view is logically cleaner and handles empty descriptions without a separate presupposition mechanism | ⚠️ They partly answer different questions: logical regimentation versus ordinary use. Strawson's original gap treatment is influential but later theories also model presupposition failure as falsity or through other semantic/pragmatic mechanisms. |
| <b>Descriptive metaphysics is circular or conservative:</b> it protects the scheme used to state its own conditions                                        | Strawson accepts an internal task: radical revision and scepticism must begin within some scheme. The cost is that description alone cannot prove the scheme uniquely correct or unrevisable.                                                          |

## 6. COMMON UPSC TRAPS ⚠️

| Trap                                             | Discrimination                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
|--------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Quine <i>rejects</i> empiricism"                | No — he retains sensory evidence and scientific naturalism while rejecting two dogmas.                                                                                                                              |
| "Quine says analytic truths don't exist"         | Not exactly. He attacks the non-question-begging explication needed for a foundational boundary. Entrenchment is not a new definition of analyticity.                                                               |
| "Strawson's 'person is primitive' = dualism"     | Wrong. Primitive is conceptual priority, not a third substance. It undercuts the Cartesian starting point without mechanically disproving every dualist thesis.                                                     |
| "Strawson's 'person is primitive' = materialism" | Also wrong. A person has <i>both</i> M-predicates and P-predicates; it is not a mere body. Materialism (identifying persons with bodies alone) loses P-predicates.                                                  |
| "Quine is a logical positivist"                  | No. He is the positivists' most devastating <i>internal</i> critic. He accepts empiricism but rejects both pillars on which positivism stood.                                                                       |
| "Basic particulars = atoms / ultimate simples"   | No. Basic particulars are <i>macroscopic</i> material bodies and persons — the things we actually identify and re-identify in ordinary experience. Not microphysical.                                               |
| "Web of belief = arbitrary revision"             | No. Experience, predictive success, conservatism, simplicity and minimum mutilation constrain revision.                                                                                                             |
| "Ontological commitment = count the nouns"       | No. Commitment is read from bound variables after logical regimentation; ontology-choice is a further question.                                                                                                     |
| "A sound-only world is simply impossible"        | No. Strawson asks what analogue of space would be required for objective identification in such a scheme.                                                                                                           |
| "'On Referring' is part of the syllabus"         | Not directly — the syllabus says "Critique of Empiricism; Basic Particulars and Persons." But "On Referring" illustrates Strawson's method and is often asked in combination with Russell (who IS in the syllabus). |

## 7. KEYWORD & STATEMENT BANK

| #  | Item                                                                                                                                     | Use                                              |
|----|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------|
| 1  | ✓ "Our statements about the external world face the tribunal of sense experience not individually but only as a corporate body." — Quine | Confirmation holism                              |
| 2  | ✓ "Any statement can be held true come what may, if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system." — Quine                 | No statement immune — web of belief (2025 Q4(b)) |
| 3  | ✓ "No statement is immune to revision." — Quine                                                                                          | Corollary of holism                              |
| 4  | ✓ "The concept of a person is logically prior to that of an individual consciousness." — Strawson                                        | Person as primitive                              |
| 5  | ⚠ Descriptive metaphysics = "content to describe the actual structure of our thought about the world" — Strawson                         | Opening move of <i>Individuals</i>               |
| 6  | ⚠ "To be is to be the value of a bound variable." — Quine                                                                                | Ontological commitment criterion                 |
| 7  | ⚠ Circle of synonymy–definition–interchangeability–semantic rules                                                                        | How Dogma 1 fails                                |
| 8  | ⚠ M-predicates (material) + P-predicates (personal)                                                                                      | Structure of the person concept                  |
| 9  | ⚠ Basic particulars = material bodies + persons                                                                                          | Strawson's ontology                              |
| 10 | ⚠ Presupposition (Strawson) vs assertion (Russell) of existence                                                                          | "On Referring" vs "On Denoting"                  |

## RESTORED 2018/2020 DOCTRINE DOSSIER

### Quine and the a priori as an "article of faith"

- ⚠ "Metaphysical article of faith" is the **2018 PYQ's framing**, not a verified verbatim Quine quotation. Do not place it in quotation marks as Quine's own formula.
- ✓ Quine attacks the analytic/synthetic distinction needed to isolate truths held independently of experience. Definitions, synonymy and analyticity form a circle unless grounded in a non-question-begging behavioural or semantic criterion.
- ✓ Holism makes revision a matter of degree across the web of belief; early Quine includes logic in principle, while pragmatic conservatism and later "change of logic, change of subject" cautions qualify the slogan.
- ? **Objection** → **reply**: revisability does not show that every proposition has the same status. Quine replies with gradients of entrenchment rather than a sharp a priori boundary.

## Strawson: spatio-temporal identification

-  Objective thought requires a public framework in which enduring material bodies can be reidentified across places and times. Persons are basic because both physical and mental predicates apply to the same reidentifiable subjects.
-  The framework is a condition of our conceptual scheme, not a psychological image or an inference from private sense-data.

## CORPUS-DRIVEN DEPTH DELTA (complete 2018–2025 audit)

-  **Priority:** Primary ownership rises to 9 of 112 parts; 2022 remains the only year without an owned part.
-  **Required doctrinal depth:** The restored papers add Strawson's person concept, spatio-temporal identification of basic particulars and Quine's charge that Kantian a priori knowledge becomes a "metaphysical article of faith".
-  **Trap / answer consequence:** Do not treat Strawson's spatio-temporal scheme as merely empirical psychology or Quine's naturalism as the rejection of every revisable conceptual distinction.

## 8. PYQ ROUTING (2018–2025)

 **Corpus signal:** 9 primary-owned question-parts out of 112. The local Paper I corpus is continuous from 2018 through 2025. Cross-links do not create duplicate ownership.

| Year | Question | Marks    | Exact demand                                                                                                                                       | Answer route                                                                                                                           |
|------|----------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2018 | Q1(e)    | 10 marks | How does Strawson explain the concept of person in his philosophy? Discuss.                                                                        | person as primitive → physical/psychological predicates → self-/other-ascription → neither Cartesian dualism nor reductive materialism |
| 2018 | Q2(c)    | 15 marks | How does Quine show that the notion of a priori knowledge as discussed by Kant is 'a metaphysical article of faith'? Give reasons for your answer. | label as PYQ framing → analytic/synthetic explication failure → holistic revisability → logic qualification → Grice–Strawson objection |
| 2019 | Q1(e)    | 10 marks | Explain Quine's arguments against synthetic-analytic distinction.                                                                                  | two classes of analytic truth → synonymy/definition → interchangeability → semantical rules → limited conclusion                       |

| Year | Question | Marks    | Exact demand                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 | Answer route                                                                                                                             |
|------|----------|----------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2020 | Q3(b)    | 15 marks | Evaluate the role of spatio-temporal thinking in objective thinking with reference to Strawson's theory of basic particulars.                                                                                                                | objective identification → re-identification → unified framework → auditory-world analogue → internal/transcendental limitation          |
| 2021 | Q3(b)    | 15 marks | What according to Strawson are basic particulars? What reasons does Strawson offer to believe that 'material bodies' and 'persons' are basic particulars? Critically discuss.                                                                | bodies as public anchors → persons as primitive basic particulars → reference/predication → alien-scheme/circularity objection           |
| 2021 | Q3(c)    | 15 marks | Critically examine Quine's postulate of empiricism without the dogmas with reference to his 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.                                                                                                                      | both dogmas → corporate testing → web/revision constraints → empiricism retained → arbitrariness/analyticity objections                  |
| 2023 | Q4(a)    | 20 marks | Why does Strawson consider person to be a primitive concept? What implication does it have for the mind-body dualism? Discuss.                                                                                                               | predicate duality → self-/other-ascription → conceptual priority → dualism/no-ownership foils → explanation-versus-dissolution verdict   |
| 2024 | Q4(c)    | 15 marks | Explain the nature of the two dogmas that Quine refers to in his paper 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'.                                                                                                                                           | define both dogmas → failed analyticity explications → reductionism → holism/pragmatism → bounded criticism                              |
| 2025 | Q4(b)    | 15 marks | "We can affirm the truth of any sentence in our total system, in the face of whatever experience, just so long as we are prepared to make adjustments elsewhere." Discuss this statement in the light of Quine's 'Two Dogmas of Empiricism'. | preserve conditional clause → conjunction under test → compensating revisions → pragmatic/minimum-mutilation constraints → no relativism |

See the [Western Philosophy PYQ Bank, 2018–2025](#).

## 9. ANSWER ARCHITECTURE (10 / 15 / 20 marks) ⚠

### 10-mark: "Explain Quine's arguments against the analytic-synthetic distinction." (2019)

State : Logical positivists distinguish analytic (true by meaning) from synthetic (true by fact).

Quine : "Analytic" cannot be non-circularly defined:  
analytic → synonymy → definition → presupposes synonymy (CIRCULAR);  
or → interchangeability salva veritate → requires "necessity" → presupposes  
analyticity (CIRCULAR);  
or → semantic rules of L → "analytic-in-L" → presupposes what we want to define.

Result : The principled analytic boundary fails; centrality explains differential practical revisability within the web, not a replacement definition of analyticity.

Assess : Grice & Strawson reply: we can sort cases pre-theoretically.  
Quine: pre-theoretical sorting ≠ principled philosophical distinction.

### 15-mark: "Discuss quotation on holism — web of belief." (2025)

Frame : Quine, "Two Dogmas" – after demolishing both the analytic/synthetic distinction  
and reductionism, offers confirmation HOLISM as the positive replacement.

Expo : (i) Statements face experience as a "corporate body," not individually.  
(ii) Web metaphor: experience touches the periphery; interior = logic, maths.  
(iii) Conflict at the edge → choice about where to revise.  
(iv) "Any statement can be held true come what may" – revise elsewhere.  
(v) "No statement is immune to revision" – not even logic.

Consequence: No sharp analytic/synthetic or a priori/a posteriori line.  
Theory-choice is pragmatic (simplicity, conservatism, fecundity).  
Positivist meaning-criterion collapses.

Assess : Strengths – dissolves positivist dogmatism; captures actual scientific practice  
(Newtonian revision; the Neptune/Vulcan pair; the quantum-logic debate opened by  
Birkhoff-von Neumann 1936 and pressed as an \*empirical\* revision of  
logic by  
Putnam 1968).  
Weakness – if logic is revisable, what constrains rational belief? Risk  
of  
"anything goes" (mitigated by Quine's pragmatic conservatism).

Close : Holism liberates empiricism from atomism – the "web" is a more faithful model of knowledge than the "bucket" (individual sentence → experience pairs).

## 20-mark: "Why does Strawson consider person a primitive concept? Implications for dualism." (2023)

Frame : The mind-body problem: Descartes = two substances; no-ownership = no subject;

Strawson rejects BOTH – proposes person as logically primitive.

Body-A : Descriptive metaphysics – describe our actual conceptual scheme.

In our scheme, we identify persons as single entities bearing BOTH M-predicates

(material: "weighs 70 kg") AND P-predicates (personal: "is in pain").

Body-B : The argument from other-ascription: to self-ascribe pain, I must be able to

ascribe it to OTHERS (public meaningfulness condition). I identify others as

persons – embodied subjects – by observing behaviour. P-predicates have DUAL

character: ascribable to self without observation, to others on the basis of

observation. This is possible only if the subject is a PERSON – not a pure mind.

Body-C : Implication for dualism: dualism DECOMPOSES person into mind + body and then

cannot put them together (interaction problem). Strawson: person is NOT composed

of two substances; it is LOGICALLY PRIOR to both "mind" and "body." The decomposition is illicit – person is the unanalysable starting point.

Also blocks no-ownership: if no subject, P-predicates lose their sense (you cannot deny what you need to state the denial).

Assess : Strengths – dissolves the problem by refusing its dualist premise; faithful to

how we actually use "person" in ordinary life and law.

Weaknesses – does not explain HOW the person unifies mental and physical (the

"hard problem"); "primitive" may be a name for the mystery, not its solution.

Still, as descriptive metaphysics it is powerful – dualism's question may simply

be ill-formed.

Close : The person is not mind-plus-body; it is what makes attributing both minds and

bodies intelligible. Strawson does not solve the mind-body problem – he dissolves the premise that generates it.

## D. DIRECTIVE DECODER ⚠ — what each command word obliges you to *do* here

| Directive                                                                                    | What it demands                                                             | Structural obligation for this file                                                                                                                                            | Fatal error                                                                         |
|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Critique of empiricism — discuss</b>                                                      | Quine's printed burden, with Strawson only as a bounded connective contrast | Quine: two dogmas, holism and empiricism retained; add one sentence that Strawson's positive framework also pressures sense-datum reconstruction.                              | Turning the item into one joint anti-empiricist doctrine.                           |
| <b>Comment on the quotation</b><br>(2025 Q4b "any statement can be held true come what may") | the <b>conditional clause</b> is the doctrine                               | Explain via Duhem–Quine: <i>modus tollens</i> condemns only the conjunction, so the choice of what to revise is not evidential. Then the Neptune/Vulcan pair.                  | Quoting the first half and calling it relativism.                                   |
| <b>Examine the analytic/synthetic distinction</b> (2018, 2019, 2021, 2024)                   | the failed explications as a <i>chain</i> , then the holistic alternative   | Analytic → meaning → synonymy → definition → interchangeability <i>salva veritate</i> ; then the limitation of semantical rules, Grice–Strawson's reply and Quine's rejoinder. | Inferring from one missing definition that no sentence can ever be called analytic. |
| <b>Explain the theory of basic particulars</b> (2021 Q3b)                                    | show why they are <b>basic</b> , i.e. an argument from identification       | Re-identification requires a single spatio-temporal framework; sense-data are private, momentary and non-spatial; ∴ material bodies.                                           | Listing what a basic particular is.                                                 |
| <b>Discuss the theory of persons</b> (2023 Q4a, 2021 Q3b)                                    | the <b>primitiveness</b> argument, against <b>two</b> rivals                | M-predicates and P-predicates; the argument that P-predicates must be ascribable to self and others alike; then Cartesian dualism <i>and</i> the no-ownership theory refuted.  | Refuting only dualism.                                                              |
| <b>Distinguish descriptive from revisionary metaphysics</b>                                  | give Strawson's <b>own</b> examples and the point of the distinction        | Descriptive: Aristotle, Kant. Revisionary: Descartes, Leibniz, Berkeley. Point: revisionary metaphysics is in the service of descriptive.                                      | Two definitions with no examples.                                                   |
| <b>Assess indeterminacy of translation</b>                                                   | the <b>gavagai</b> construction, then the behaviourist premise              | Rival manuals; the identity-predicate move; then Chomsky's underdetermination objection and take a side.                                                                       | Asserting "meanings are indeterminate."                                             |

| Directive                           | What it demands              | Structural obligation for this file                                                                                               | Fatal error      |
|-------------------------------------|------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------|
| <b>Do you agree? / Substantiate</b> | a ruling in line 1, defended | E.g. "Quine's holism succeeds against reductionism and overreaches about logic — as his own <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> concedes." | Neutral summary. |

## V. GRADED VERDICT BANK — executable closing positions

| Sub-topic                   | 10-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                | 15-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                               | 20-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Analytic/synthetic</b>   | Quine does not show that familiar classifications are unintelligible; he argues that available explications cannot ground the sharp foundational boundary empiricism required. | ...Grice and Strawson preserve ordinary contrast-cases but may not supply the theoretical account Quine demands.                                                                                              | The dispute concerns standards of explication. Quine strongly pressures the distinction's foundational use while leaving room for more modest semantic or ordinary classifications.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| <b>Holism / Duhem–Quine</b> | Statements face experience as a corporate body, so no single statement is individually confirmable — which by itself destroys the second dogma.                                | ...Duhem confined the thesis to physics and exempted logic and mathematics; Quine's extension to <i>all</i> knowledge is the controversial step, and it is what makes the analytic/synthetic collapse follow. | Holism is right about confirmation and overstated about revisability. Quine's own later work concedes as much: <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) invokes the maxim of minimum mutilation and argues that to deny a law of logic is to change the subject. The defensible position is Duhem's thesis with Quine's motivation — testing is holistic, choice of revision is pragmatic, and logic is revisable in a sense so attenuated that nothing much follows from it. |

| Sub-topic                            | 10-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                            | 15-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                       | 20-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                     |
|--------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Radical translation / gavagai</b> | There is no fact of the matter about reference, because no behavioural evidence can fix the apparatus of individuation.                                                    | ...The argument's force is exactly proportional to its behaviourist premise about evidence, and Quine retains a verificationist criterion of <i>factuality</i> while rejecting verificationism about <i>meaning</i> . | Chomsky's objection identifies the pressure point: if underdetermination does not make physics factless, why does it make translation factless? Quine's asymmetry — that there is nothing beyond dispositions for a manual to be right about — is a naturalist thesis, not a result of the argument, so the argument establishes its conclusion only for those already persuaded of the naturalism. What survives independently is the negative result that use alone does not fix reference — a result the later Wittgenstein reaches by a wholly different route. |
| <b>Ontological commitment</b>        | "To be is to be the value of a bound variable" audits the commitments of a regimented theory rather than counting its nouns.                                               | ...The criterion presupposes choices of theory and regimentation; it does not make those choices automatically.                                                                                                       | Ontological relativity adds a separate framework-dependence thesis. Quine and Carnap overlap in rejecting theory-free ontology but differ over analyticity and the status of framework choice.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                      |
| <b>Basic particulars</b>             | Material bodies are basic because identification and <b>re-identification</b> demand a single spatio-temporal framework that private, momentary sense-data cannot provide. | ...The argument is transcendental in form — from an undisputed fact about reference to its necessary conditions — which is why <i>Individuals</i> and <i>The Bounds of Sense</i> are one project.                     | The conclusion is about our <b>conceptual scheme</b> , not about mind-independent reality, and Strawson says so: his metaphysics is descriptive. An empiricist may therefore accept the whole argument as conceptual geography while denying that it settles ontology. Whether descriptive metaphysics can be more than a very good map of how we think is the standing question about Strawson's programme, and the honest answer is that he never claimed more.                                                                                                   |

| Sub-topic                               | 10-mark verdict                                                                                                                                      | 15-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                   | 20-mark verdict                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
|-----------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Persons</b>                          | "Person" is a <b>primitive</b> concept: it is not compounded from a mind and a body, because both dualism and the no-ownership theory presuppose it. | ...The decisive argument is that P-predicates must be ascribable to others on behavioural grounds and to oneself not on those grounds; a concept with that dual condition cannot be constructed from either half. | Strawson defeats Cartesianism more economically than any argument from interaction: he does not ask how mind and body can interact but shows that the question presupposes a prior unity that neither term can supply. The cost is that "primitive" marks the end of analysis rather than an explanation — which is a legitimate result for descriptive metaphysics and an unsatisfying one for anybody who wanted the mind-body problem solved rather than dissolved. |
| <b>Strawson vs Russell on referring</b> | On Strawson's account, existence is presupposed by the use; when it fails, the attempted assertion lacks an ordinary true/false evaluation.          | ...This is a claim about ordinary use, not a knock-down refutation of Russellian logical regimentation.                                                                                                           | The approaches partly answer different questions. Later presupposition theories also divide between gap, falsity and pragmatic treatments, so Strawson's 1950 proposal must not stand for all of them.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                 |

## T. QUOTATION, DATING & PROVENANCE DISCIPLINE

**Both write in English, so the discipline here is dating, attribution and formula-accuracy — the commonest failures on this item are misattributed technical proposals.**

| Item                                              | Correct provenance                                                                                            | Caution                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
|---------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Two Dogmas of Empiricism"                        | <i>The Philosophical Review</i> , <b>January 1951</b> ; revised in <i>From a Logical Point of View</i> (1953) |  The famous "web of belief" / "field of force" passage is §6, "Empiricism without the Dogmas." Cite the section.                                                                                                                     |
| "Any statement can be held true come what may..." | "Two Dogmas," §6                                                                                              |  Safe verbatim.  Do not truncate it — the conditional clause ("if we make drastic enough adjustments elsewhere in the system") is the doctrine. |
| "To be is to be the value of a bound variable"    | Standard slogan for the criterion developed in "On What There Is" ( <i>Review of Metaphysics</i> , 1948)      |  Treat as a canonical summary rather than assume every printed wording is a verbatim sentence; it is <b>not</b> from "Two Dogmas."                                                                                                   |
| <i>Word and Object</i>                            | <b>1960</b>                                                                                                   | Radical translation, gavagai, stimulus meaning, analytical hypotheses — <b>ch. 2</b> .<br> The <b>epigraph is Neurath's boat</b> — cross-cite <a href="#">Logical-Positivism.md</a> §P.                                              |

| Item                                                    | Correct provenance                                                                                                                                                                                              | Caution                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                |
|---------------------------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| "Ontological Relativity"                                | Dewey Lectures, <b>1968</b> ; in <i>Ontological Relativity and Other Essays</i> ( <b>1969</b> ) — the same volume as " <b>Epistemology Naturalized</b> "                                                        | ⚠ Do not date naturalised epistemology to 1951.                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                        |
| Quantum logic                                           | ✅ Birkhoff and von Neumann, "The Logic of Quantum Mechanics," <i>Annals of Mathematics</i> , 1936 — the formal proposal. ✅ Putnam, "Is Logic Empirical?", 1968 — the claim that logic is empirically revisable. | ❌ Never write "Putnam/Birkhoff" as a joint proposal, and never merge the dates. ? Add that Putnam later abandoned the position, and that Quine's own <i>Philosophy of Logic</i> (1970) resists revision of logic via "change of logic, change of subject" and the <b>maxim of minimum mutilation</b> . |
| Duhem                                                   | <i>La Théorie physique: son objet, sa structure</i> (1906); Eng. <i>The Aim and Structure of Physical Theory</i> (tr. Wiener, 1954)                                                                             | ⚠ Duhem restricted the thesis to <b>physics</b> and exempted logic and mathematics. The label " <b>Duhem–Quine thesis</b> " is later shorthand for two <b>non-identical</b> claims — say so.                                                                                                           |
| Popper                                                  | <i>Logik der Forschung</i> (1934); Eng. 1959                                                                                                                                                                    | ⚠ Popper accepts the logical point and answers it methodologically; do not present him as denying Duhem–Quine.                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| <i>Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics</i> | 1959                                                                                                                                                                                                            | Basic particulars Pt I; persons ch. 3; the subtitle contains the phrase "descriptive metaphysics" — quote the <b>subtitle</b> , it is exact.                                                                                                                                                           |
| "On Referring"                                          | <i>Mind</i> , 1950                                                                                                                                                                                              | ⚠ Predates <i>Individuals</i> by nine years; it is not an application of descriptive metaphysics but its precursor.                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Grice & Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma"               | <i>The Philosophical Review</i> , 1956                                                                                                                                                                          | ⚠ Co-authored with H. P. Grice — attributing it to Strawson alone is a standard slip. Note also the spelling: <i>Defence</i> (British).                                                                                                                                                                |
| <i>The Bounds of Sense</i>                              | 1966                                                                                                                                                                                                            | The " <b>non-sequitur of numbing grossness</b> " charge against Kant's Second Analogy is here — see <a href="#">Kant.md</a> §3.6.2. ✅ Safe verbatim; it is Strawson's own phrase.                                                                                                                      |
| <i>Introduction to Logical Theory</i>                   | 1952                                                                                                                                                                                                            | The dissolution of the problem of induction, <b>ch. 9</b> .                                                                                                                                                                                                                                            |
| Chomsky's objection                                     | "Quine's Empirical Assumptions," in <i>Words and Objections</i> (1969)                                                                                                                                          | ✅ Attribute the underdetermination objection to Chomsky, not to "critics."                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Davidson                                                | "Radical <b>Interpretation</b> " (1973)                                                                                                                                                                         | ⚠ <b>Interpretation</b> , not translation — the change of word marks the change of doctrine (no shared observation-base assumed; charity and a truth-theory instead).                                                                                                                                  |

✗ **Never write:** that Quine "rejected empiricism" (he calls his own position empiricism without the dogmas); that Strawson "defended empiricism" (he defends a distinction *against Quine*, which is not the same thing); that Duhem and Quine hold the same thesis; or that Quine denied the existence of meaning *tout court* rather than of meanings as determinate entities.

## 10. LINK-OUTS

- [Logical Positivism](#) — the empiricism Quine reforms; the analytic/synthetic and reductionist pillars he attacks.
- [Kant](#) — the synthetic a priori that Quine's holism blurs; the transcendental argument form Strawson revives.
- [Moore-Russell-EarlyWittgenstein](#) — Russell's theory of descriptions (which Strawson challenges in "On Referring"); logical analysis tradition both Quine and Strawson inherit.
- [Later Wittgenstein](#) — parallel critique of the picture/verification model of meaning; Strawson's "connective analysis" is closer to Wittgenstein's descriptive method than to Russell's reconstructive one.
- [Empiricism](#) — Hume's empiricism as the ancestor that Quine reforms.
- [A priori / a posteriori](#) — Quine rejects a sharp foundational a priori/a posteriori line.
- [Substance across Western](#) — Strawson's basic particulars as the modern "substance" question.
- [Critiques of Metaphysics](#) — Quine's holism as a solvent; Strawson's descriptive metaphysics as a *revival*.
- [Self and Liberation](#) — Strawson's person concept vs Indian *ātman/anātman* debates.
- Cross-paper: [Notions of God](#) — ontological commitment (Quine) bears on whether "God" is a value of a bound variable.
- PYQ bank: [Western Philosophy PYQs, 2018–2025](#)

## SOURCES

- W.V.O. Quine, "Two Dogmas of Empiricism" (1951), reprinted in *From a Logical Point of View*.
- W.V.O. Quine, *Word and Object* (1960) — indeterminacy, ontological relativity.
- P.F. Strawson, *Individuals: An Essay in Descriptive Metaphysics* (1959).
- P.F. Strawson, "On Referring" (1950) — the rival to Russell.
- H.P. Grice and P.F. Strawson, "In Defence of a Dogma" (1956) — reply to Quine.
- Y. Masih, *A Critical History of Western Philosophy* (Quine and Strawson chapters).
- Anthony Kenny, *A New History of Western Philosophy*, vol. 4.
- Roger Gibson, *The Philosophy of W.V. Quine* (overview of the system).
- A.C. Grayling (ed.), *Philosophy 2: Further Through the Subject* (Strawson's descriptive metaphysics).

## 11. 2026 ownership update and exact demand

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**2026 Q3(a), 20 marks:** "Why are states of consciousness ascribed to anything at all and why are they ascribed to the same things to which we also ascribe physical properties? How does Strawson answer these questions in his work *Individuals*?"

This is directly owned by Strawson's theory of persons. The answer must connect the possibility of P-predication to one identifiable subject of both physical and psychological predicates; explain the asymmetry of self- and other-ascription; and show why an independently identifiable Cartesian ego cannot ground the practice. It is not an invitation to replace *Individuals* with reactive attitudes or a generic mind-body essay.

## 12. Additional precision controls

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### Quine

- **Canonical notation:** first regiment the accepted theory; then inspect what its bound variables must range over. The slogan is a commitment criterion after theory choice, not noun-counting and not an ontology-selection algorithm.
- **Indispensability:** Quine's parsimony does not entail nominalism at any cost. Abstract commitment can follow indispensable quantification in best science; the broader Quine-Putnam argument is not identical with the slogan.
- **Proxy functions:** systematic object permutations can preserve sentence-level truth, strengthening the claim that reference is fixed only relative to a background interpretation.
- **Underdetermination:** evidential equivalence between scientific theories does not by itself yield translation indeterminacy. The latter adds Quine's contested naturalistic thesis that no further semantic fact selects a manual.
- **Logical laws:** the early essay includes logic in revisability in principle. Later Quine's minimum-mutilation conservatism and "change of logic, change of subject" warning qualify any casual appeal to quantum logic.

### Strawson

- **Subject-predicate framework:** ordinary predication normally presupposes successful identification of a subject. Feature-placing expressions complicate but do not abolish the framework.
- **Other minds:** public criteria for other-ascription are not reductive behaviourism. The same P-predicate is other-ascribed on behavioural/situational criteria and self-ascribed without observation.
- **Uniqueness and context:** "On Referring" distinguishes sentence meaning from a speaker's use on an occasion. Context can fix whom a speaker intends without making every uniqueness condition the conversational assertion.
- **Presupposition caution:** the meaningful sentence-type does not become meaningless. Strawson's original treatment concerns an unsuccessful use that ordinarily fails to make a true-or-false assertion; later theories vary.
- **Reactive attitudes:** *Freedom and Resentment* is source-recognized bounded enrichment, not printed core or independent PYQ ownership here.

## 13. Exact owned PYQs through 2026

| Year | Part  | Marks | Primary demand                                                        |
|------|-------|-------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 2018 | Q1(e) | 10    | Strawson's concept of person                                          |
| 2018 | Q2(c) | 15    | Quine on the Kantian a priori                                         |
| 2019 | Q1(e) | 10    | argument against analytic/synthetic distinction                       |
| 2020 | Q3(b) | 15    | spatio-temporal thinking and objective thought                        |
| 2021 | Q3(b) | 15    | material bodies and persons as basic particulars                      |
| 2021 | Q3(c) | 15    | empiricism without the dogmas                                         |
| 2023 | Q4(a) | 20    | person as primitive and mind-body dualism                             |
| 2024 | Q4(c) | 15    | nature of the two dogmas                                              |
| 2025 | Q4(b) | 15    | web of belief and revisability quotation                              |
| 2026 | Q3(a) | 20    | states of consciousness and physical properties in <i>Individuals</i> |

No Topic 11 question was primary-owned in 2022. Russell's 2023 Q4(b) and related description questions remain Topic 06-owned; Logical Positivism questions remain Topic 07-owned even where Quine supplies criticism.

## 14. Closed-book register

1. State the **two-project firewall** before comparison.
2. Reproduce the analyticity circle: meaning -> synonymy -> definition/interchangeability/necessity/semantical rules -> circularity or residual unclarity.
3. Derive holism from the rejection of sentence-by-sentence reduction.
4. Qualify universal revisability through pragmatic conservatism and later logical caution.
5. Separate commitment, indispensability, translation indeterminacy, reference inscrutability and ontological relativity.
6. Derive bodies from identification plus re-identification in one public space-time.
7. Derive persons from one subject of M- and P-predicates plus self-/other-ascription.
8. State the Russell-Strawson split as asserted existence/uniqueness versus presupposition in use, without calling the sentence meaningless.
9. End comparative answers with a layered verdict, not a fabricated Quine-Strawson school.

## 15. Recall prompts

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- Can you explain why definition cannot create cognitive synonymy by stipulation alone?
- Can you derive not- (H and A) without pretending that evidence names the guilty conjunct?
- Can you distinguish stimulus meaning, observation sentence, analytical hypothesis, inscrutability and indeterminacy?
- Can you explain why "primitive person" is neither dualism, materialism nor a third substance?
- Can you state what descriptive metaphysics proves internally and what it leaves externally open?
- Can you answer the 2026 question without drifting into reactive attitudes?